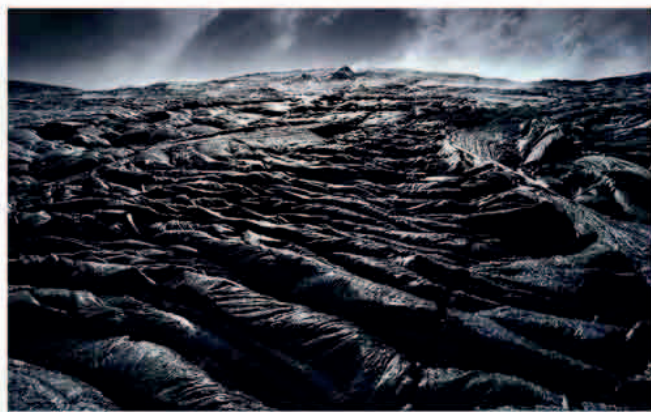


Earth's crust

The hot, mobile rock of Earth's thick mantle is enclosed by an outer skin of cool, brittle rock known as the crust. This is divided into oceanic and continental crust. The thin oceanic crust covers more than two-thirds of Earth's surface and is mainly made of a dark, heavy rock called basalt, while the thicker continental crust is made of lighter rock such as granite. The hard bedrock of both types of crust is often covered by softer rock.



OCEANIC CRUST

The crust beneath the ocean floors is about 5 miles (8 km) thick. It is made of basalt lava flows, which erupt from oceanic volcanoes. The basalt lava is basically the same as the rock of the mantle below, but not as heavy. This is because some of the heaviest ingredients of the mantle rock are left behind when it forms molten lava.

◀ BASALT LAVA FLOW

This lava erupted from a Hawaiian volcano is cooling and solidifying into black basalt—the same rock that forms the bedrock of the ocean floors.

CONTINENTAL CRUST

In mountainous regions, the crust that forms the continents can be 43 miles (70 km) deep. It is made of many types of rock, but at its heart lies very hard rock such as granite. This rock is lighter than the basalt that forms the ocean crust because it lacks some of its heavier ingredients.

▼ GRANITE OUTCROP

The cores of continents contain granite, which is paler than basalt because it contains fewer dark, metallic ingredients such as iron.

